Pension Benefit Guaranty Corporation

One-page brief

Priority: 24 of 33 (score 2.5). **FY2026 outlays:** $10.6B (USAspending). **As of:** 2026-10-27. Public data only.

Bottom line

PBGC pays pensions for failed plans and, since 2021, has paid Special Financial Assistance (SFA) grants to rescue multiemployer plans. The SFA program showed a concrete, public failure: Central States got about $127M too much because 3,479 dead participants were counted as alive, since PBGC was not checking SSA's death file until November 2023. Other SFA plans may carry the same error.

Exposure

- $10.6B in outlays and $91B in budgetary resources in FY2026.
- Central States alone received a $35.8B SFA grant; the $127M overpayment was about 0.35% of it. PBGC says it will recover funds tied to deceased participants from other plans.

Public data we can use

- **PBGC SFA application and approval listings** (plan, amount, date).
- **Form 5500 filings (DOL EFAST):** participant counts, deaths reported, and actuarial data for every plan.
- **PBGC OIG reports** and congressional oversight letters.

Detection plays

1. **SFA census checks:** plans whose participant counts or death rates in the SFA application differ from their own Form 5500 history and actuarial norms.
2. **Benefit payee checks** (with SSA data): payees with no sign of life.

First prototype

A plan-level table comparing SFA application data with Form 5500 trends, ranking plans by likely overcounted participants.

Geodesic Solutions: geodesic.pro *Contact: Steve Taylor, Managing Partner: taylor@geodesic.pro*

Limits

Participant-level data is not public; the screen finds plans to audit, not individual dead payees.

Who to take it to

PBGC Multiemployer Program, PBGC OIG, and DOL's Employee Benefits Security Administration.

Sources

- PlanSponsor: Central States to repay $127M SFA overpayment
- PBGC OIG semiannual report (SR-2026-01)
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)

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